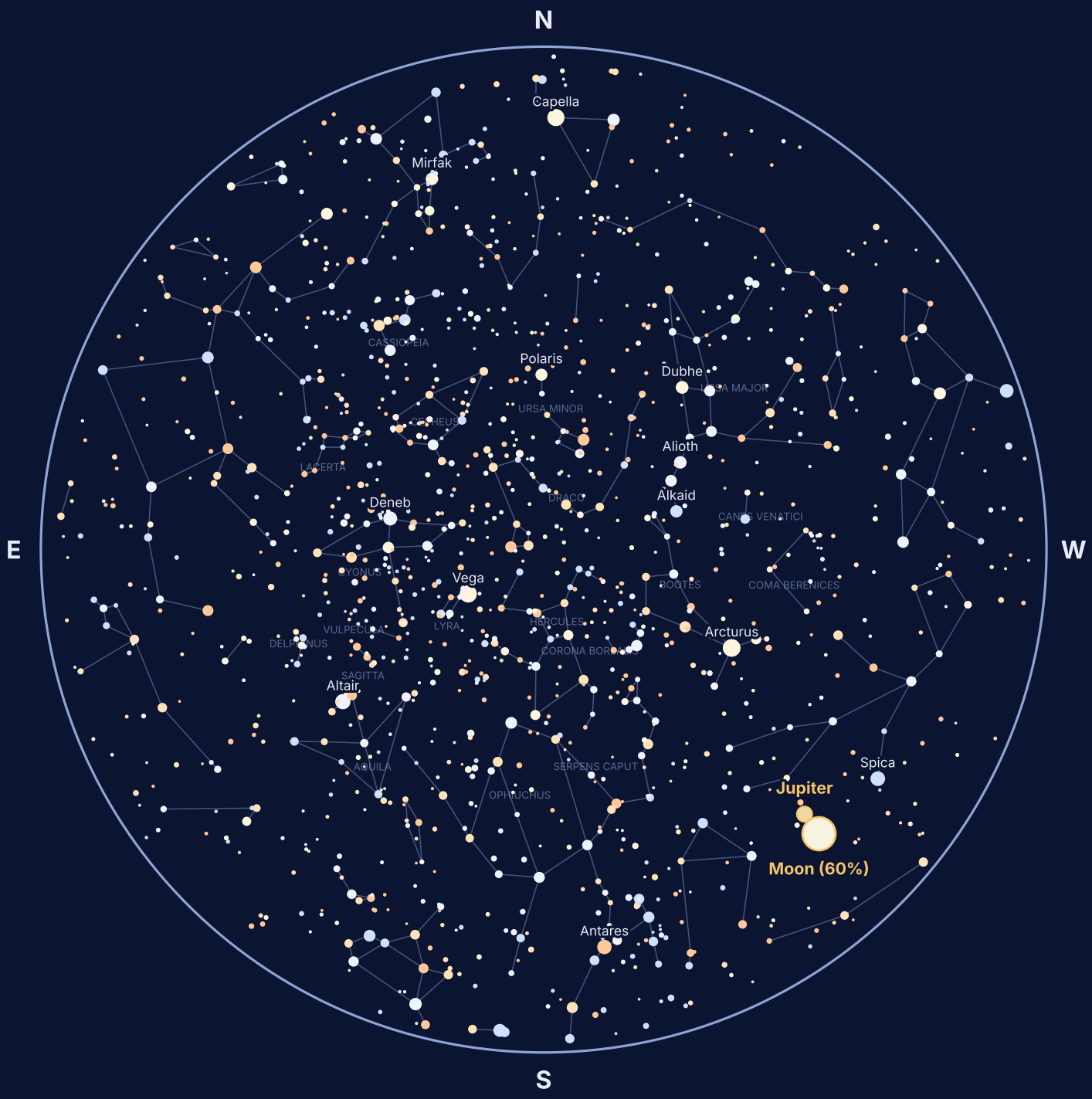
The night Maya was born

London · Saturday 16 July 1994 · 22:30



The sky above London, latitude 51.51°, longitude -0.13°

With love, from the sky.

A letter from the sky

This is a letter from the sky. It's about one night: Saturday, the sixteenth of July, nineteen ninety-four, in London. It was the night Maya was born.

Nobody photographs the sky on nights like that. Everyone is looking somewhere else. So here is what was happening above you, worked out from the movements of the Earth, the Moon and the planets.

The Sun had set at ten past nine at night. It was one of those nights when the sky never quite gets dark.

The Moon was waxing gibbous, six tenths lit. It hung a little way up in the south-west, in front of the stars of Virgo.

The planets were out too. Jupiter was a little way up in the south-west. Jupiter is the biggest planet of all. More than a thousand Earths could fit inside it.

That night Jupiter sat right beside the Moon, as if keeping it company.

Before dawn, Mars and Saturn would rise as well.

Among the stars, Arcturus was high up in the south-west. The light from Arcturus that shone on London that night had left the star around nineteen fifty-seven. Vega was very high in the south-east. The light from Vega that shone on London that night had left the star around nineteen sixty-nine. Altair was high up in the south-east. The light from Altair that shone on London that night had left the star around nineteen seventy-seven.

Directly overhead was the constellation of Draco. Draco is a dragon, curling its long tail between the two bears near the top of the sky.

And the Southern Delta Aquariids meteor shower was active, so now and then a shooting star crossed the dark. The sky will never be arranged in exactly this way again. The Moon, the planets and the turning Earth will not line up like this for thousands of years.

But every year, around July, the same stars come back to the same places in the evening sky. So when you look up and find Arcturus, you are looking at the sky of that night. With love, from the sky.